Mobile UX Prototyping, UXD-M
Exercise, Winter term 2026/27

Exercise Sheet 04
Prof. Dr. Simon Nestler

Friction by design · Notifications: designing against the filter

What is this sheet about?

This sheet puts both directions of interruption to your own prototype: the resistance it places in the user's way, and the interruptions it pushes into their day. You audit a team member's flow for friction and sort each point by whose interest it serves, then build a notification concept for your own project. Every friction point that only serves the organization has to be defended or dropped.

Organisation: Work in teams of three, four only if the numbers do not divide. On this sheet, the letters A, B and C stand for the team members, and D for a fourth person; settle who is who before the first assignment. Assignments 1, 2 and 4 are team work, assignment 3 is individual work on your own seminar project.

What you take with you: At the end of the session, **every person** holds the team's friction decisions (assignment 2) and their own notification concept (assignments 3 and 4). The sheet has no upload of its own. Its results count in **Part C**, the final presentation, where the whole exercise track U1–U5 is relevant, and they go into your **seminar paper**, with a focus on notifications.

Part B in this session: Part B takes place within the time slot of this exercise, for each group in its own session (23 Nov for MUXP.1, 30 Nov for MUXP.2). Each team presents the results of exercise sheets 02 and 03 – severity verdict, design question and fidelity block, iteration protocol, audit and responses – for 15 minutes with the lecturer (20 points; upload by Fri 20 Nov, for both groups).

First assignment (35 minutes): Your own prototype meets both directions of interruption today: *friction*, the resistance an app puts in the user's way (topic 7), and *notifications*, the interruptions an app pushes into the user's day (topic 8).

Start with a friction audit. Each team member hands their prototype (or, if it is not clickable yet, its central flow as sketches) to a neighbor: A audits B, B audits C, C audits A (in a group of four: C audits D, D audits A). As the auditor, walk through the central flow once, count the taps, and mark every friction point: every moment where the flow slows the user down, asks for a confirmation, demands input, or makes them wait. For each friction point, note its source, checked in the order from Topic 7: *user value* (security, error prevention), *organizational interest* (data, newsletter, account wall), or *nobody thought about it*. Guiding questions for the audit:

- Does this step protect the user, their assets, third parties, or only the organization?
- What would go wrong, concretely, if this step were removed?
- Is the effort of the step scaled to what is at stake?
- In a multi-step flow: does the screen show the current step and the total number of steps (*"2 of 3"*)?
- If the flow opens with an onboarding tour: can the user skip it, pause it and call it up again later?

Return the annotated flow to its owner at the end of the audit.

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Second assignment (40 minutes): Now each of you decides for your own prototype: pick the one friction point that matters most, and either remove it or keep it deliberately. The claim "my prototype has no friction" is inadmissible; every flow has some. Defend your decision in the team along the two lines from Topic 7:

- **Interest direction:** whom does the friction serve? The user, their assets, third parties, or the organization? The protection map from Topic 7 has these four directions.
- **Proportionality:** what is at stake in this step, and is the friction scaled to it? If you keep the friction, name the protective tool it uses or should use: undo window, confirmation, cooling-off, speed bump.

The team's job is resistance: before a decision becomes final, the other team members argue the opposite case for five minutes. Document each decision on half a page: the friction point (screen, step, interaction), the decision (remove or keep), and the two justifications.

Third assignment (45 minutes): Turn to notifications. First, pool your 24-hour notification protocols within the team: one total number and the three-way split *wanted / tolerated / annoyed me* per person. The protocol comes from the Topic 7 bridge task, which is voluntary and goes on the Padlet; this assignment does not wait for it. If you have no protocol, open your phone's notification history for yesterday, count what is there, sort it into the three categories and mark the number as an estimate. An estimate labelled as an estimate is admissible here, an unlabelled one is not. Look at the distribution for two minutes. Which category dominates, and what does that mean for anyone who wants to add another notification to these days?

Then, individually, write a notification concept for your seminar project – starting from your twelve-minute draft from Topic 8 if you have one, from scratch if not: one page, containing exactly these four elements:

1. **Occasion classes,** the kinds of moments that justify a notification from your app (typically 2–4 classes; naming a class you deliberately *exclude* counts in your favor).
2. **Channel per class:** push, badge, in-app inbox, e-mail, or silence; one line of reasoning per class. For push, add the moment your app asks for permission (opt-in honesty, Topic 8).
3. **Frequency budget:** a number per day or week, per class. "As needed" fails the sheet.
4. **The renunciation sentence** *"We do not notify when …"*. It must exclude something your engagement metrics would want, and you must name that price in one sentence.

An AI sparring partner is allowed for this assignment.

Fourth assignment (30 minutes): Exchange the one-pagers within the team and test them against the filter. Assume an aggressive platform filter with the four mechanisms from Topic 8: AI summary, cooldown, bundling and focus modes; iOS 26 and Android 16 (both 2025/26) ship parts of exactly this. Apply three hard rules: salvos within minutes get throttled, three similar pushes become one summary line, and weeks without interaction lead to quiet demotion. For each occasion class in your neighbor's concept, answer two questions: Would this notification survive the filter? And what single line would the summary produce, and would that line still deserve the user's glance? Then attack the renunciation sentence: is the named price real, or would the engagement metrics not even notice? Finally, sharpen your own one-pager based on the feedback you received.

Keep the team's friction decisions (assignment 2) and your individual, sharpened notification concept (assignments 3 and 4). Both go into Part C and into your seminar paper.